Safe System of Work

COSHH – Hazardous Substances in the Workshop

Ref. SSoW-070	Author.	Derick Bibby	Date:	10.11.2026
Reviewed By: Name	Lee Hardy		**Date of Review:**	29.08.2026
Record of Amendments				
			Next Review Due Date:	**28.08.2027**

Overview

This Method Statement is intended to provide, as far as is reasonably practicable, a safe system of work for the use, storage and disposal of substances hazardous to health in Fox Group wagon fitters and fabrication workshops, and during mobile and site repairs. It details the steps to be taken and the method used to carry out the task safely. All personnel carrying out this activity are expected to co-operate fully with the methods described and follow the control measures identified in the associated COSHH assessments.

Scope

- All fitters, fabricators, apprentices, drivers and visitors working in Fox Group workshops or carrying out mobile repairs.
- All hazardous substances used or produced in the workshop: oils, fuels, AdBlue, coolants, brake fluid, solvents and aerosols, adhesives, sealants, fillers, paints, battery acid, welding fume, dusts and diesel engine exhaust.

Hazards Identified

- Skin contact – dermatitis, oil acne, and skin cancer from prolonged contact with used engine oil
- Inhalation of vapours, mists, fume and dust – irritation, asthma, lung disease, cancer
- Eye contact – splashes from fluids, acids and aerosols
- Ingestion – contaminated hands, decanting into drinks bottles
- Fire or explosion – flammable solvents, aerosols, fuels and vapours
- High-pressure injection of oil, grease or fuel through the skin
- Environmental pollution from spills and incorrect disposal

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) Requirements



Personal Protective Equipment – each fitter / fabricator is equipped with the following:

- Safety Footwear
- Overalls (changed when contaminated – never put oily rags in pockets)
- Full Length High Visibility Clothing in yard and on site
- Chemical-resistant gloves as stated on the COSHH assessment – disposable nitrile for oils and fuels as standard (not latex); heavier-duty nitrile or neoprene for solvents and acids
- Safety Glasses; goggles or face shield when decanting, handling acid, or there is a splash risk
- RPE where the COSHH assessment requires it (e.g. FFP3 for dusts, A2P3 combined filters for solvent spraying) – tight-fitting RPE must be face-fit tested

Equipment or Machinery Used.

- Workshop COSHH register and Safety Data Sheets (SDS)
- Labelled dispensing containers, funnels, oil drainers and fluid recovery units
- Metal flammable-liquid storage cabinet; bunded oil and chemical storage
- Tailpipe exhaust extraction (where fitted) and workshop ventilation
- Spill kits, eye-wash station, hand-washing facilities with skin cleanser and after-work cream
- Lidded metal bins for oily rags; segregated hazardous-waste containers

COSHH Relevant.

COSHH assessments for each product and process are held in the workshop COSHH register and are available from the Workshop Supervisor and on request. Read the COSHH assessment and SDS before first use of any product. Welding fume is covered separately by WF042 Welding Fume and Local Exhaust Ventilation; diesel and AdBlue refuelling by SSoW-069.

Emergency Procedures.

Should an accident or incident occur on Fox Group sites, it will be reported to the site responsible person and the Fox Group accident reporting procedure will be followed. The incident must also be reported through the near miss QR code on the front page of the RAMS and up around Sandham House.

Emergency Contact.

Emergency Contact Details (IN CASE OF EMERGENCY OR INCIDENT)

Fox Group Breakdown – 07923447383

Emergency services – 999 · First aid: see WF041 First Aid · Spills: see WF040 Emergency Spill Response

Description of Activity/Task.

Fox Group expects all workshops and sites to comply with the Control of Substances Hazardous to Health Regulations 2002 (COSHH). Exposure to hazardous substances must be prevented, or where that is not reasonably practicable, adequately controlled. The order of control is: eliminate or substitute the product; use engineering controls (extraction, enclosed systems, tools that keep a working distance); then safe working practice; and finally PPE.

The Workshop Supervisor is responsible for keeping the COSHH register up to date, making sure no new product is brought into the workshop without an SDS and COSHH assessment, and making sure controls are in place and used.

Statutory Examinations.

- LEV (including welding extraction, tailpipe extraction, spray booths and dust extraction): thorough examination and test at least every 14 months; weekly user checks recorded (see WF042).
- RPE: face-fit test for tight-fitting facepieces before first issue and on change of model/size; pre-use checks by the wearer; maintenance of reusable RPE at least monthly where used.
- Health surveillance via the occupational health provider where the COSHH assessment requires it – e.g. skin checks for those regularly in contact with oils and solvents; respiratory surveillance for isocyanate, stainless-steel welding and other asthmagen exposure.
- Storage cabinets, bunds and spill kits inspected monthly by the Workshop Supervisor.

METHOD STATEMENT

Before using any substance

- Check the product is on the workshop COSHH register. If it is not, do not use it – speak to the Workshop Supervisor.

- Read the label and the COSHH assessment. Know the hazard symbols, the PPE required, and the first aid and spill actions.
- Use the least hazardous product that will do the job (e.g. water-based degreaser instead of solvent, brush-on instead of aerosol).
- Never decant into unlabelled containers, food or drink containers. All dispensing containers must carry the product name and hazard label.
- Do not eat, drink, smoke or vape in the workshop. Wash hands before breaks and at the end of the shift.

Common workshop substances and key controls

Substance / process	Main risks	Key controls
Used engine oil, gear and hydraulic oil	Dermatitis, oil acne, skin cancer (used engine oil)	Nitrile gloves; drain into oil drainers or recovery units, not open trays; wipe spills immediately; change contaminated overalls; no oily rags in pockets; wash skin promptly.
Diesel and AdBlue	Skin irritation, eye irritation, flammable (diesel)	Follow SSoW-069. Nitrile gloves and glasses; no containers for refilling; fuel line work only with fuel retriever / sealed container, away from ignition sources.
Brake and parts cleaners, aerosols, solvents, degreasers	Vapour inhalation (dizziness, headaches), dermatitis, highly flammable	Prefer water-based cleaners or brush-on products; use in a ventilated area; never near welding, grinding or other hot work; no aerosol use in pits; store in the flammables cabinet; empty aerosols in the designated waste.
Antifreeze / coolant	Toxic if swallowed (ethylene glycol); hot coolant scalds	Only open cooling systems when cold (WF023); nitrile gloves; collect in labelled containers; never leave coolant in open trays.
Brake fluid	Eye and skin irritation; damages paint	Nitrile gloves and glasses; bleed into a sealed container.
Battery acid / batteries	Burns to skin and eyes; hydrogen gas – explosion	Follow WF020. Goggles or face shield and acid-resistant gloves; eye-wash available; no sparks or naked flames near charging batteries.
Grease and high-pressure hydraulics	Injection through skin – can cause loss of limb	Isolate and release pressure before work (SSoW-071). Never feel for leaks with hands – use card. Any injection injury is a medical emergency: go to A&E straight away.
Adhesives, sealants, fillers, 2K paints and hardeners	Dermatitis; isocyanates – asthma	Only trained staff; brush/roller application under COSHH assessment; spraying of isocyanate paints only in a suitable spray booth by staff under respiratory health surveillance – otherwise do not spray.
Dusts – brake dust, grinding and sanding dust, sweeper debris	Lung damage; possible asbestos in older brake linings and gaskets	Never use compressed air to blow out brake drums or clean clothing; use wet-wipe or brake-cleaning equipment; extraction for grinding (WF001, WF007). Suspect asbestos – stop, do not disturb, report to supervisor.
Diesel engine exhaust (DEEE) in the workshop	Lung cancer, respiratory irritation	Keep engine running inside to a minimum; use tailpipe extraction where fitted; open doors and use ventilation; do not run engines in pits or near people working.
Welding and cutting fume	Lung cancer and other lung disease	Follow WF042 – LEV for all indoor welding, RPE where LEV is not adequate and for all outdoor welding.

Protecting your skin

- Avoid contact first – use tools, funnels, drainers and enclosed systems rather than hands.
- Wear the gloves stated on the COSHH assessment. Change gloves when torn or contaminated inside, and do not reuse disposable gloves.
- Clean skin with the workshop skin cleanser and water – never with solvents, fuel, thinners or abrasive powders.
- Use after-work cream to replace skin oils. Pre-work "barrier" creams are not a substitute for gloves.
- Check your hands regularly for redness, dryness, itching, cracking or rashes and report any symptoms to your supervisor straight away.

Storage

- Flammable liquids and aerosols are stored in the metal flammables cabinet, kept closed when not in use, away from hot works, heaters and electrical equipment.
- Only the quantity needed for the job (no more than one shift's supply) is kept at the workbench or vehicle.
- Oils and chemicals in drums or IBCs are stored on bunds or in bunded stores. Keep acids, oxidisers and flammables segregated.
- Gas cylinders stored and secured as WF002 Compressed Gas Cylinders.

Spills and waste

- Contain spills immediately with the spill kit and inform the Workshop Supervisor (see WF040 Emergency Spill Response). Do not wash spills into drains.
- Waste oil into the bunded waste-oil tank; used oil filters drained and placed in the filter bin; oily rags and absorbents in the lidded metal bin.
- Coolant, brake fluid, batteries, aerosols and contaminated filters (including LEV filters) are hazardous waste – segregated and collected by a licensed carrier with a consignment note.

If something goes wrong

- Skin contact: remove contaminated clothing, wash skin with soap and water.
- Eye contact: rinse at the eye-wash station for at least 10–15 minutes and seek first aid.
- Inhalation: move to fresh air; seek first aid if symptoms continue.
- Swallowed: do not induce vomiting – seek medical attention and take the SDS or label with you.
- High-pressure injection injury: treat as a medical emergency – go to A&E immediately even if the wound looks minor.
- Report all incidents and near misses through the Fox Group reporting procedure.

Under the Health and Safety at Work Act, you are required to inform your Manager of any Health and Safety issues you may have that would affect or endanger yourself or others whilst carrying out your contracted duties.

Related sections

WF001 Abrasive Wheels · WF002 Compressed Gas Cylinders · WF007 Dust · WF012 Refuelling · WF016 PPE · WF020 Working with Batteries · WF023 Working on Cooling Systems · WF040 Emergency Spill Response · WF041 First Aid · WF042 Welding Fume and LEV (draft) · SSoW-069 Refilling HGV with Diesel and AdBlue · SSoW-071 Isolation and Stored Energy (draft)

References

- Control of Substances Hazardous to Health Regulations 2002 (as amended)
- HSE – Used engine oil (motor vehicle repair): https://www.hse.gov.uk/mvr/topics/oil.htm
- HSE – Common motor vehicle repair topics / COSHH essentials: https://www.hse.gov.uk/mvr/topics/index.htm
- HSE INDG356 – Reducing ill health and accidents in motor vehicle repair: https://www.hse.gov.uk/pubns/indg356.pdf
- HSE – Preventing skin problems: https://www.hse.gov.uk/skin/employ/prevention.htm
- HSE – Health surveillance in the motor vehicle industry: https://www.hse.gov.uk/mvr/bodyshop/health-surveillance.htm
- HSE – LEV frequently asked questions: https://www.hse.gov.uk/lev/faqs.htm